THIS WEEK'S FILE · FOUNDER FILE #009

MAOR SHLOMO, BASE44 AND THE $80 MILLION HEADLINE

An Israeli founder came home from military reserve duty, built an AI app builder on his own, and sold it to Wix a few months after launch. The headline said $80 million. The detail is stranger, and more useful: a small cheque up front, and a great deal more for what happened next.

THE FILE

FOUNDER	Maor Shlomo, Founder, now at Wix
COMPANY	Base44
FOUNDED	2024 (public launch early 2025)
HQ	Israel
SECTOR	AI app builder (vibe coding)
STAGE	Acquired by Wix (June 2025)
FUNDING	None raised. Sold for a reported $80m plus earn-outs
MODEL	Subscriptions to an AI tool that builds apps from plain language

Hello again, and welcome to File #009. Thank you for reading.

On 7 October 2023, Maor Shlomo was called up for reserve duty in the Israeli military. He was 29 or 30, and by any normal measure already a success: he had co-founded a data company at 24 and run it as chief executive while it raised about $125 million and grew past a hundred employees.

During that deployment, his unit was asked to help a nonprofit that needed some simple internal software. Shlomo collected quotes from developers. The prices shocked him. These were basic tools, the kind of thing that feels as if it should take an afternoon, and they were going to cost a small organisation a fortune.

He kept thinking about that. About fourteen months later he launched a product that builds software from a plain-English description. Three weeks after launch it was earning at a rate of a million dollars a year. About four months after launch, Wix bought it.

The headlines said: solo founder, six months, $80 million. Each of those three claims is partly true, and the gaps are the most interesting part of this file. (All figures are in US dollars.)

THE SHORT VERSION

- **Who:** Maor Shlomo, an Israeli founder, previously co-founder and chief executive of the data company Explorium.
- **What:** Base44, a tool that turns a written description into a working app. It is part of a category people have started calling “vibe coding”.
- **Why it matters:** it’s the best-documented recent case of one person building an AI product alone, with his own money, and selling it fast. Because the buyer is a listed company, we can also see what happened afterwards.
- **The number to remember:** $18 million. That, according to the Israeli business paper Globes and to summaries of Wix’s own annual report, is roughly what was paid in cash at the start. Most of the rest of the money depended on what Base44 did next.

THE FOUNDER

Shlomo isn’t a newcomer who got lucky. He co-founded Explorium in 2017, when he was 24. It sells tools that help companies find and use outside data, and it was backed by Insight Partners, one of the big American technology investors. He ran it for about seven years.

So he knew exactly what a venture-backed company feels like: the fundraising, the board, the hundred-person payroll. Base44 was a deliberate turn away from all of it.

He left Explorium in late 2024, after returning from reserve duty. Calcalist, the Israeli financial daily, describes Base44 as a side project that began on a trip he took after his service. He has said publicly that he has severe ADHD. And he built Base44 with no co-founder, no investor and, at the start, no employees.

He turned down offers from Israeli venture funds. He was the only shareholder.

WHAT BASE44 DOES

You type what you want, such as “an app where my five staff can log their hours and I can approve them”, and Base44 builds it. It makes the screens and the database, handles the log-in and puts the result on the internet. You don’t see any code unless you ask to.

That’s the whole pitch, and it’s aimed squarely at the nonprofit from his reserve duty: people who need a simple tool and can’t afford a developer. Plans ran from about $20 to $200 a month.

He wasn’t alone in the idea. Lovable, Bolt and Replit were all doing versions of the same thing, with tens or hundreds of millions of dollars behind them. Shlomo had his savings and a laptop.

THREE WEEKS

Base44 came out of stealth in early 2025. The first users, by the account he gave on Lenny Rachitsky's podcast, were three friends.

He spent nothing on marketing. He did what several founders in this series have done, and posted what he was building, day by day, on LinkedIn and X, including the awkward parts. He published what the AI models were costing him and what he was earning. In a category full of companies losing money on every customer, here was a founder showing his working and a profit.

It spread quickly. According to Remarkable Magazine, Base44 passed $1 million in annualised revenue within three weeks and $1.5 million within four.

Counting the users is harder. Calcalist reported more than 100,000 at the time of the sale. Other reports said 250,000. The podcast said 400,000. They were counted on different dates and probably in different ways, and we can't tell you which is right. All of them are a lot for a product a few months old.

Two weeks before the deal, Shlomo posted his profit for May 2025: about $189,000. He had forecast $100,000.

WHAT "SOLO" MEANT

The headlines called it a one-man company. At launch that was accurate. By the time Wix announced the deal on 18 June 2025, it wasn't. Calcalist counted six employees, and fewer than ten people in all. Wix told another outlet eight.

So the fair description is that one person built the product and ran it through its first, fastest stretch, then hired a handful of people when it became too much.

He has been honest about what that stretch was like. Speaking at a conference run by EY Israel, he was asked whether it had been lonely. "Yes, absolutely I felt lonely," he said. He also said that being what he called a non-democratic company, one where a single person makes every decision without a meeting, was a huge advantage early on.

Both of those are worth hearing if you're tempted by the solo route. It was fast, and by his own account it was lonely.

How did one person keep up with rivals that had whole engineering departments? Largely by using the same kind of tool he was selling. The promotional notes for his podcast interview say he hadn't written a line of front-end code himself in three months, and the episode is billed around AI writing 90 percent of his code. (You'll often read that he spent 20 to 30 percent of his time automating the business. We couldn't find where that comes from, so we've left it out.)

THE DEAL, READ CAREFULLY

Here is the headline: Wix buys Base44 for $80 million.

Wix is an Israeli company, listed in New York, that lets people build websites without code. An AI that builds whole apps from a sentence is either its future or its replacement, so buying Base44 made sense. “There’s no better fit,” Shlomo said. He told reporters Wix was probably the only company that could help Base44 scale without slowing it down.

Now the detail. We’ve pieced this together from Wix’s announcement, Calcalist, Globes and summaries of Wix’s annual report. We tried twice to open the relevant note in the report itself and couldn’t, so treat the precise figures as reported, not confirmed by us.

PIECE	WHAT’S REPORTED	SOURCE
Headline price	About $80 million of “initial consideration”, plus further payments to 2029 that depend on performance	Wix’s announcement, June 2025
Cash paid at the start	About $18 million	Globes; summaries of Wix’s annual report
Earn-out, valued on day one	About $74 million, bringing the total to about $92 million	Summaries of Wix’s annual report
Retention pay	Wix expected about $25 million of expense in 2025 to keep the team. This is on top of the price	Wix’s announcement
Earn-out paid, early 2026	A further $38 million, in Wix shares	Globes
Earn-out due, mid 2026	A further $41 million after more targets were beaten	Calcalist, citing Wix’s results
Total so far	More than $150 million to Shlomo	Calcalist, August 2026

If those reports are right, “$80 million in cash” was never accurate. He got a modest sum up front and a promise of much more if the product kept growing. An earn-out is exactly that: the buyer pays later, and only if agreed targets are hit.

It turned out to be a very good bet, because the product didn’t just keep growing. It took off.

Wix hasn’t published the terms of its agreement with him. Calcalist notes that this leaves investors unsure how much more he could be owed.

WHAT HAPPENED NEXT

- **November 2025.** Wix said Base44 had 2 million users, seven times as many as when the deal closed, with more than 1,000 new paying subscribers a day. Its share of its market had gone from low single digits to more than 10 percent.
- **March 2026.** Wix reported that Base44 had passed $100 million in annualised recurring revenue.

- **May 2026.** About $150 million.
- **August 2026.** Calcalist put it at $200 million. Wix also announced Base 1, Base44's own AI model.

A year earlier this was a side project with three friends using it.

There's a cost, and it shows up in Wix's own accounts. Every time someone builds an app with Base44, an AI model has to run, and that costs money. Wix said Base44 began 2026 with a gross margin of "near zero", meaning it was spending almost everything it earned just delivering the product. The plan to fix that is Base 1: run your own model and stop renting someone else's. Wix said it expected a margin of about 60 percent in the second half of 2026.

Wix also spent heavily to feed the growth. Its annual report says marketing costs rose from $175.6 million to $243.6 million in 2025, "mainly due to Base44", and that many Wix staff were moved onto it. When Wix announced that spending in November 2025, its shares fell more than 15 percent in a morning. Calcalist's sharper observation was that Base44's success is masking a slowdown in Wix's original business.

So the founder's side project is now, in effect, the main thing a company worth billions of dollars is betting on.

WHAT YOU CAN COPY, AND WHAT YOU CAN'T

Copyable:

- **Start from a price that shocked you.** He didn't begin with a technology. He began with a quote for simple software that seemed absurdly high.
- **Build in public, including the costs.** His posts about what the AI cost him and what he earned did more than any advert.
- **Be profitable early.** A profit of $189,000 in a month meant he didn't need investors, which meant he could say no to them, which meant he owned all of it when the offer came.
- **Use the tools yourself.** He competed with funded teams by letting AI write most of the code.

Not copyable:

- **His track record.** He'd already run a company that raised $125 million. People listened when he posted, and Wix knew who it was dealing with.
- **The timing.** Early 2025 was the first wave of excitement about AI app builders. It's a crowded field now.
- **The buyer.** A large listed company felt threatened by exactly this technology and needed an answer quickly. You can't plan on finding a buyer in that position.

Try this

Find your shocking quote. What have you been quoted for recently that made you think "surely not"? Software, a report, a design, a translation? Ask whether an AI tool can now do a rough version, and whether other people would pay for that.

Find your first three users. His were friends. Name yours before you build, and ask them whether they'd actually use it.

Work out your cost per customer. If your product runs an AI model every time someone uses it, calculate what one active customer costs you a month. Base44 grew to $100 million with almost no margin, and it needed Wix's money to do it.

Read the deal, not the headline. If you ever sell a business, ask for three numbers in writing: cash on the day, payments that depend on your staying, and payments that depend on results. Assume only the first is certain.

WHAT COULD GO WRONG

The cost of every answer. Near-zero margin at the start of 2026 is a serious weakness. The 60 percent target depends on a new in-house model working as hoped.

Rivals. Lovable, Replit, Bolt and others are well funded and moving fast, and the big AI labs can build the same thing.

Dependence on one buyer's patience. Wix is spending hundreds of millions on Base44 while its older business slows. Shareholders have already flinched once.

The founder. He's now an employee, with large payments tied to targets through 2029. What he says publicly is shaped by that. He could also simply leave once the payments are made.

The numbers we couldn't pin down. User counts conflict. The early revenue figure comes from one report. And the deal terms come from press reports and summaries of a filing we couldn't open ourselves.

WHAT TO WATCH

1. **The earn-out.** How much more Wix pays, and whether it ever publishes the terms.
2. **The margin.** Whether Base 1 really takes it to around 60 percent.
3. **Wix itself.** Whether Base44 lifts the whole company or just hides the decline of the rest.
4. **Shlomo.** Whether he stays to 2029, and what he builds if he doesn't.

He saw a nonprofit quoted a fortune for a simple tool, and he built something that could do the job for $20 a month. Then he took a deal that paid him most of the money only if the product kept growing, and it grew far beyond what the headline price assumed.

That's File #009. Thank you for reading it. If it made you think of someone, forward it along, and if there's a founder you'd like to see opened next, tell us at info@aifounderfiles.com. File #010 lands next Sunday.

Where this came from: Wix's announcement, results and annual report, Calcalist Ctech, Globes, Remarkable Magazine and Lenny's Podcast. User, revenue and staff figures conflict between sources, and we say so. The split of the deal between cash and later payments comes from press reports and summaries of Wix's filing; we couldn't open the note ourselves. We haven't spoken to Maor Shlomo. Claude, made by Anthropic, helped research and draft this file. Spotted a mistake? Email info@aifounderfiles.com and we'll correct it.

SOURCES

- Vibe coding fever: solo entrepreneur's Base44 acquired by Wix for $80 million, Calcalist Ctech (18 June 2025). calcalistech.com
- Base44 becomes Wix's surprise growth engine with 2 million users, Calcalist Ctech (19 November 2025). calcalistech.com
- Wix pays $38m earnout payments for Base44, Globes (2026). en.globes.co.il
- Base44 coverage, Calcalist Ctech (including the August 2026 report on earn-out payments). calcalistech.com
- Six months, $80 million: how Maor Shlomo built Base44 alone, Remarkable Magazine. remarkablemag.com
- Solo founder, $80M exit, 6 months: the Base44 bootstrapped startup success story, Lenny's Podcast. lennysnewsletter.com
- Wix further expands into vibe coding with acquisition of Base44, Wix press release (18 June 2025), via ResearchPool. app.researchpool.com
- Wix.com Ltd. Form 20-F for fiscal 2025 (U.S. SEC). sec.gov
- Base44 revenue, valuation and news, Sacra (estimates). sacra.com